

Glossary

abbreviation

A shortened form of a word, often with one or more periods to represent missing letters.

abstract noun

The name given to something that cannot be touched, such as a concept or a sensation.

accent

The way in which a language is pronounced, which varies across geographic areas.

acronym

An abbreviation made up of the initial letters of the main words in a phrase. These letters are pronounced as a word (rather than as separate letters), which represents the meaning of the original phrase.

active voice

When the subject of a sentence is performing the action of the verb, and the object is receiving it.

adjective

A word that describes a noun.

adjective phrase

A group of words that describe a noun or pronoun.

adjective prepositional phrase

A prepositional phrase that describes a noun.

adverb

A word that modifies the meaning of an adjective, verb, or other adverb.

adverb prepositional phrase

A prepositional phrase that describes a verb.

adverbial phrase

A group of words that behave in the same way as an adverb and answer questions such as: How? When? Why? Where? How often?

alliteration

The repetition of certain letters or sounds for effect.

Arabic numerals

Everyday numerals such as 1, 2, and 3.

attributive position

When an adjective is placed directly in front of the noun or pronoun that it is modifying.

auxiliary verb

A “helping” verb such as *be* or *have* that joins the main verb in a sentence to the subject. Auxiliary verbs are also used with other words to form contractions and negative sentences.

bibliography

A list of all the sources used in a piece of academic work.

blog

An online journal that contains the writer’s comments and reflections. It is updated regularly.

cardinal number

A counting number such as *one*, *two*, *ten*, or *twenty-one*.

clause

A grammatical unit that contains a subject and a verb. Sentences are made up of one or more clauses.

collective noun

The name given to a collection of individuals—people or things.

colloquial language

The language that is used in everyday speech.

colloquialism

A word or phrase used only in informal speech.

command

A sentence that gives an instruction.

common noun

The name given to everyday objects, places, people, and ideas.

concrete noun

The name given to an ordinary, physical thing, such as an object or animal.